

Vote on automatic license plate reader program removed from Austin council agenda after privacy fears

Several Austinites voiced opposition to the program, including concerns over federal immigration agents accessing data.

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AUSTIN, Texas — Austin Police Chief Lisa Davis voiced her support on Tuesday for continuation of [the city's automatic license plate reader \(ALPR\) program](#).

During that same city council work session, several Austinites also voiced privacy concerns, including fears that federal immigration agents could access the data.

The city council had been expected to vote on Thursday whether to extend the pilot program expiring June 21. But on Tuesday evening, City Manager T.C. Broadnax removed the item from the council's Thursday agenda, effectively ending the program on June 30.

"Given concerns expressed today, I have decided to withdraw this item from the agenda at this time to provide more opportunities to address council members' questions and do our due diligence to alleviate concerns prior to bringing this item back to City Council for consideration." Broadnax said in his message to the mayor and council.

Since the trial run launched in March 2024, the city has installed 40 ALPRs at fixed spots around town and nearly 500 in police vehicles.

ALPRs compare the license plate of each car passing by with a database of stolen or wanted vehicles. If they get a match, police get alerted.

An audit released in May found 75 million scans led to 165 arrests, 133 prosecutions and one missing person found.

"We're talking about capital murders," Assistant Chief Sheldon Askew said during Tuesday's meeting. "We're talking about murders, robberies, aggravated assaults, sexual assaults and kidnappings."

Askew told council members on Tuesday that ALPRs also helped Austin police find 176 stolen cars. He and Davis praised the technology for helping APD solve crimes despite staffing being 300 officers short of their target.

Askew told the council ALPR data is deleted after seven days unless it's part of a criminal investigation, with limits on who can access it.

However, several speakers at Tuesday's meeting shared concerns.

"Any data collection, you cannot prevent what happens to that data later," one woman said.

Many worried agencies outside of Austin, especially federal immigration agents, could access it.

"The data is going to be also shared with the Department of ICE [Immigration and Customs Enforcement]," said a woman translating for a 13-year-old girl.

Askew said the Austin Police Department has received eight total requests for data from outside agencies.

"Has APD shared any data with ICE or any immigration related entity that's seeking that data?" asked Councilmember Marc Duchon of District 10.

"The answer is absolutely not," Askew answered.

Davis acknowledged the fear of Hispanic residents citywide.

"I take this very seriously," Davis said. "But I do feel that there is a way to do this and to do it in a way that we can be successful and have a program here as a large city that addresses violent crime. We can do both."

Still, Siegel said a flaw in the city's contract lets Flock, the ALPR company, access the data and the city has no say about what Flock does with it.

"I would ask this council to discontinue the program," Siegel said.

On Wednesday morning, Siegel will join colleagues and community groups at a news conference against ALPRs.